towards authority, his bongo-drum performing, his relationships with women, both deep and shallow, his attendance at strip clubs, his attempts, late in life, to reach the obscure country of Tuva in central Asia, and many other schemes. Undoubtedly, he must have been extraordinarily clever, as his lightning quickness at calculation, his exploits involving safe-cracking, outwitting security services, deciphering ancient Mayan texts—not to mention his eventual Nobel Prize—clearly demonstrate. Yet none of this quite conveys the status that he unquestionably has amongst physicists and other scientists, as one of the deepest and most original thinkers of this century.

The distinguished physicist and writer Freeman Dyson, an early collaborator of Feynman's at a time when he was developing his most important ideas, wrote in a letter to his parents in England in the spring of 1948, when Dyson was a graduate student at Cornell University, "Feynman is the young American professor, half genius and half buffoon, who keeps all physicists and their children amused with his effervescent vitality. He has, however, as I have recently learned, a great deal more to him than that. . . ." Much later, in 1988, he would write: "A truer description would have said that Feynman was all genius and all buffoon. The deep thinking and the joyful clowning were not separate parts of a split personality. . . . He was thinking and clowning simultaneously."* Indeed, in his lectures, his wit was spontaneous, and often outrageous. Through it he held his audiences' attention, but never in a way that would distract from the purpose of the lecture, which was the conveying of genuine and deep physical understanding. Through laughter, his audiences could relax and be at ease, rather than feel daunted by what might otherwise be somewhat intimidating mathematical expressions and physical concepts that are tantalizingly difficult to grasp. Yet, although he enjoyed being center stage and was undoubtedly a showman, this was not the purpose of his expositions.

* The Dyson quotations are to be found in his book *From Eros to Gaia* (Pantheon Books, New York, 1992), pages 325 and 314, respectively.